In late March an activist group, which came to be known as Pan Zagar (flower speech),[14] gave a press conference speaking out against hate speech, including that of famously anti-Muslim Buddhist leaders such as U Wirathu.[15] The campaign, launched by a respected former political prisoner and backed by key activists in Myanmar civil society, gained quick momentum; over the next month, they helped to inspire — and support — anti-hate speech demonstrations on streets in more than forty-two cities and townships in Myanmar. The campaign also generated a strong presence on social media,[16] in an attempt to shatter what appeared to be a developing anti-Muslim "echo chamber" in Myanmar.[17] As the campaign attracted prominence, however, it also attracted counter-attacks. Among these, an imposter Pan Zagar Facebook page was created at the end of April 2014, mimicking the posts of the original account and initially exhibiting no apparent differences from the original. But after a few days, it also began posting anti-Muslim content centred on the argument that the teachings of Islam constitute hate speech and that the Pan Zagar campaign thus rejected Islam.

The campaign members were unhappy at such a development and felt it was a deliberate attack, designed to discredit their efforts or use their momentum to promote inter-religious conflict.[18] As we discussed this and how to respond, I took careful note of the arguments being wielded against the campaign: the posts purported to quote Islamic teachings at length, though not in good faith, and linked back to an English-language website; the posts were Myanmar language translations of an online article entitled "Is the Quran Hate Propaganda?" (Religion of Peace 2015). The article was originally published on a website maintained by anti-Muslim activists in the US. The site is prominent in a network of websites that En-Chieh Chao (2014, pp. 2–3) has called the post-9/11 "industry of Islamophobia". A user in Myanmar was translating the page to use in an unfolding contest over the nature of free speech and religious coexistence.

The contest over Pan Zagar is an example of the use of anti-Muslim material from the US in Myanmar. It is also an example of the way that analysing anti-Muslim discourses on social media offers a mechanism for considering the influence of my presence as a researcher: posts on social media are a valuable space to examine the construction of narratives about Islam by Myanmar people who are addressing each other and, presumably, not altering their arguments to persuade a foreign researcher. The attacks on Pan Zagar, for example, were clearly addressed to a Myanmar audience —